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Chris Parker

Chris Parker has been the drummer of choice for an astonishing array of jazz and pop artists. He currently leads his own ensembles and satisfies his love of the visual arts through sketching and watercolor painting.

Chris was interviewed via Zoom on January 5, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have drummer and visual artist Chris Parker with me today. I feel like if I was introducing your father I'd say the same thing except I might say, "visual artist and drummer."

CP: Right.

MR: Is that a fair statement?

CP: It is indeed. I don't have an original thought in my head, I just sort of copied what my father did which was playing drums along with records and painting and drawing.

MR: And am I correct that your brothers then copied you?

CP: Well I think we all copied my father, at least three out of the five, three other brothers, Tony, Eric and Nicholas are all professional drummers or involved in the music business in some way. And one brother is purely an artist, although he's a great musicologist so I often ask him who's playing on this record? "It was Toots and the Maytals from 1963" and he'll tell me the whole personnel and the studio they recorded in. He's very knowledgeable about music, but doesn't actually play drums.

MR: It seems like you grew up in an incredibly creative atmosphere.

CP: Yes indeed.

MR: Did it affect — did the visual art — some kind of affect the music in some fashion?

CP: Absolutely. They're totally entwined. And I've always related the two things together and sometimes I look at a painting and like let's see for an example like a Wassily Kandinsky painting — I look at it and I say man that's Elvin Jones to the max. You know that's like totally how Elvin Jones would paint if he painted. Or I look at a painting — I mean I listen to a drummer like my friend Steve Gadd you know, and say man that is like photorealism you know, that's like Chuck Close, he's so perfect and his technique is so precise and he's got such conviction it reminds me of a certain artist you know. So for me there are two things that have always been totally intertwined and when I'm drawing I'm thinking about music and when I'm painting, when I'm drawing or painting I'm thinking about music and when I'm drumming I'm trying to visualize a perspective and a vanishing point and textures and putting different colors into the music. So the two things are completely intertwined as far as I'm concerned.

MR: I was watching a video that was connected to a recent trio record and I almost had to wind back a little bit because you were using terms — you were talking about the music but it sounded like you were talking about art. And so I — it really rang a bell with me as Lester Young might have said, because I used to work in aesthetic education and we were always trying to find those connections so to hear you say that I just thought was terrific.

CP: Oh great. Yeah I think in that video for my new CD, "Tell Me" the Chris Parker Trio, I talk about Uccello, a Renaissance Italian painter and he sort of, a lot of people think or agree that he kind of invented perspective because he did this painting that's very realistic but it also has this depth that he accomplishes by there's a tile floor and there's lances laying on the floor and there's a landscape in the background that kind of recedes even further. So yeah.

MR: Well I was — I picked out four names and I was going to print out your discography but I didn't have enough paper. So I picked four names: Lionel Hampton to Michael Bolton to Stuff to the Paul Butterfield Band.

CP: Okay.

MR: So here's a question, you're going to have to set aside your modesty I think. Why have you played and recorded with so many people? Why do they choose Christopher Parker?

CP: They couldn't get anybody else.

MR: Yeah, you were way down the line, I know.

CP: In each case it's kind of different. Let's see, Lionel Hampton was a date that Teo Macero produced and I had worked with Teo Macero on a Gato Barbieri record and he didn't scare me. He was always kind of tempestuous you know, he had a temper and his face would get red and he would yell — I saw him yell at people you know who missed an eighth note in the second bar or something. But I wasn't fazed by him on that — that's the only thing I can think of, and I got a call for this Lionel Hampton date and I was thrilled, because Lionel Hampton's records were things that I listened to as a kid and played along with and I always loved "Flyin' Home" and "Gin for Christmas" and "Ring Dem Bells" and I saw him live a bunch of times, different concerts and theaters and stuff, and I was always knocked out by him. So this date I think Grady Tate is on one side and I'm on the other side. And my side is with a great bass player Anthony Jackson and we had worked together a lot. And Joe Beck on guitar and Bobby Scott on piano. So Lionel was great. And we got along and I of course told him how much I admired him and how much I had listened to him as a kid and everything and it was wonderful. Other than that I don't know why I got the call. You mentioned Paul Butterfield — I was living in Woodstock and I initially moved there to join a rock band and then after the rock band we did one album and broke up. Then I stayed around Woodstock and played with a lot of different people like a Gospel group, a country group, a jazz trio, another rock band, a

bunch of different groups. But there's only, at that time there was only so many places to play in Woodstock and I always noticed this guy standing in the background with a fur hat, big fur hat, you could only see his face and he had this giant like an Eskimo fur hat on. And I thought you know it was a typical character in Woodstock, I had no idea it was Paul Butterfield and he had been checking me out in all these different contexts and then one day I got a call from him and I said, "Yeah, right" and I hung up. And I thought it was somebody putting me on. And he called right back and said, "No really, this is Paul Butterfield, I want to know if you want to do some playing" blah-blah-blah. And that's how he inducted me. And this wasn't the Paul Butterfield Blues band, this was a new thing that he wanted to put together with Geoff Muldaur. It ended up being called Better Days and we did two albums and then I did some other albums with him after that band broke up. But he was wonderful. Very paternal towards me, I was pretty young and he really encouraged me and I learned a lot playing with him, not to mention the other guys in the band. So that was — I just I don't know why he chose me, I guess he liked what he heard.

MR: Well in a general sense I'm thinking of the big picture. I know that musicians get a lot of gigs from referrals and let's say it's a given that Chris Parker is a good drummer, but there must be something else that you would rise above all the other fine drummers. Maybe what you bring to a session or what you don't bring. Can you work with that question?

CP: Sure. When I get a call my focus is immediately gratitude — oh my God I'm going to get to play music with these people or this artist or this singer. And I'm immediately excited about it and from the moment I get the call I start to do homework — as Richard Tee used to say to me, "You're doing the homework, Stuffy." And I research that artist, listen to everything I can find that they've recorded previously. Maybe most importantly listen to their last record or look at their last performance somehow and I take notes and I take tempo markings, you know here's the way she did this tune. If I get MP3s or in the old days cassettes in advance of the session I'll listen to those and take notes and tempo markings and write myself a little chart. Or sometimes they have the charts and here's your drum part you know and I'll start practicing that drum part as soon as I get it and fool around with it so that by the time the session day rolls around I'm really as well acquainted with the artist and his or her music as I can be.

MR: Have you ever had someone say to you, "I don't want you to do that."?

CP: Yes.

MR: Okay.

CP: Yes. And that's a point of departure, you know and at that moment — somebody said, "You're very diplomatic." So my diplomacy kind of kicks in and detente comes to mind

where okay they don't want me to do what I do naturally or instinctually or what I prepared to do when I first heard about this song or this album. So leave all that behind and start fresh. And I take their direction or the producer's direction, you know, don't do this, do this, can you make it sound like this, can you make it go faster, slower, louder, softer. Can you play with brushes? Can you play with — whatever the suggestions might be you take it all in and process it and then go forward with that. You know? So it's not that I'm changeable but I guess you could say I'm chameleon-like, you know somebody wants it to sound like a lot of times they say I want you to sound like this drummer or that, or I want this kind of feel from this record. Fine. You know I have no problem emulating Fred White, Earth, Wind and Fire, that drummer, great drummer just passed away recently, or Bernard Purdie or Grady Tate is one of my favorites, or Al Jackson or Roger Hawkins.

MR: It's funny you mentioned Bernard Purdie because he told me if someone said, "I want you to sound like Steve Gadd he would have said, "Well go get Steve Gadd then."

CP: Good for him.

MR: Yeah he was in a very playful mood I think. Have you come across an instance, it could have been for a recording session or maybe a live gig, where you knew you were going to be playing a style and you said oh I've never quite done this before? I'm thinking specifically maybe of certain Latin kinds of grooves?

CP: Yeah. I do the same kind of dive deep into research and listen to records that I have or search for records that have the feel that they're talking about. I remember doing a record with Jon Secada that won a Grammy, I don't know what year it was, maybe early 90s or something. And I was so embarrassed I put both feet in my mouth when the leader said, "This is 'Bolero.'" And I said, "Okay, 'Bolero' I've got it," and started to play like Ravel's "Bolero." He said, na-na-na-na balero. And it's just a [scats] just a very simple Latin feel like that. After that session I did a lot more research into the songo and samba and all the different Latin feels I could find, and really researched and studied with Sammy Figueroa who was in the Brecker Brothers, had him show me beats, and a couple of other great percussionists. I said show me this, show me that. And a lot of it is written out, you can find it in a book, but to have a guy who can actually show you is really important. And I shared a studio with a great Columbian percussionist, Memo Acevedo. And he was very forthcoming with not only Columbian feels but Brazilian feels and Latin feels and he's got a great Afro-Cuban rhythm book out that was filled with information. I used to teach a drummer's collective and there was a guy Frankie Malabe who would show you whatever you wanted to know, and play with you, you know set up a couple of conga drums and say here we go, count it off and tell me, "No that's not it, that's not it, you should be playing this and you don't have to play that because I'm playing that on

the tumba on the conga. You know, the bass drum goes here because, so you're not in the way of what's already there. A lot of times a Latin thing, it doesn't have drums at all, it's congas and timbales and cowbell and shaker maybe, so to fit the drumset in is a delicate operation. And there's some guys who do it really well, you know like Richie Morales, I'm thinking of a lot of guys, Vince Cherico is great, plays with Arturo O'Farrill's big band. It's a special thing to fit in with the Latin percussion and not get in the way and still have the drumset, the voice of the drumset in there.

MR: How much does it have to do with your personal ego?

CP: A lot. A lot.

MR: I mean I was going to get to Stuff later which we could do but being cognizant of what a percussionist is doing certainly applies in this situation, when you have two drummers going. And I doubt that you had discussions about who's going to do what.

CP: Never.

MR: Never. But it worked somehow.

CP: Yep. That was part of the — it sounds cliché, but part of the magic of the group was that Steve and I never discussed, you know I'll play cross stick and you go to the bell and then I'll play sixteenths on the hi-hat and you do bass drum. We never discussed a single element. We just sat down and played together. The fact that I grew up with three younger brothers and my dad playing drums in the house, often there were five sets of drums set up, made it feel pretty natural to play with another drummer. And I had done recordings, there's a Sandborn record with me and Rick Marotta playing drums, double drums, and I did a tour with Boz Scaggs with Jeff Porcaro for the first month of the tour we were playing double drums with Jeff Porcaro so the thing with Steve was great. We just hit it off personally and hit it off musically. You know, and it was part of the attraction of the group that two drummers but it wasn't super loud and it wasn't — we weren't stepping all over each other.

MR: And you could say the same thing about the two guitarists. How can a group with two guitar players and two drummers and a bassist and multi-keyboardist not be busy? And well the proof was in the records I guess.

CP: Yeah. Everybody in that group was very cognizant — to borrow your word — of what the other guy was playing and nobody was like suppressing their ego especially but everyone wanted — Gordon always equated it with a football team. You know everybody's got a job to do, you're the safety, you're the center, he was the quarterback of course but this guy's going out for a pass, this guy's going to do blocking, this guy's going to do a Hail Mary, all the football analogies really worked because that's how the band worked. You know we really chose an area and made that our turf, individually. So Eric and Cornell never got in each other's way, always complemented each other.

Although each guy, you know, got solos. Same thing with Steve and I, we each got drum solos but when we were playing as a unit everybody was very respectful of the other guy's turf. I'm sorry —

MR: Go ahead.

CP: It was that way personally too, you know nobody interfered with anybody else's offstage life but we were all supportive of each other in our offstage life and that really became exaggerated. Once we hit the stage we were totally supportive of each other.

MR: I'm glad you mentioned Gordon Edwards because this morning, actually just before I started this session with you I got up that tune "Love of Mine" — I almost had tears in my eyes. It's so perfect in every regard and just the way he sang it. And then he gets to the end and if people listen to this there's this hook and he's going, "Woman of mine/friend of mine" and then at the end he goes, "stuff of mine."

CP: Yep.

MR: Do you remember that moment specifically?

CP: Absolutely. I had only heard him sing you know a bar here and a bar there. I never heard him sing a whole tune like that. Sometimes on stage he would say you know the first line of the song, but he never actually sang like that. So on that session, to hear him sing full throated and that husky baritone, it was great. And I love the lyrics and — there's a bass player around the city named John Montegna who does a version of "Love of Mine" and sings and plays bass. Great bass player. And I heard his version and it brought it all back to me, you know Gordon singing like that. Richard sang too, he sings one called "I Need Somebody to Love" and also very poignant you know. You hear this big guy singing these very sensitive words. I love that.

MR: So how did your mother feel about having five drum sets in the house?

CP: She was accepting. You know? But one of my favorite moments was when we had five sets going, me and Tony and Eric and Nicholas and my dad, all playing — or actually my dad wasn't there, he was off in his studio I think, but the four sets of drums were going and my mother was playing piano and we were playing "Willow Weep for Me." She was pretty good. And something else she would play, "When Sunny Gets Blue" but the four guys, I think I might have been 15 and then the ages range on down. And everybody was into Led Zeppelin and John Mayall and the Heartbreakers and the Beatles and the Stones and stuff and we're banging away on "Willow Weep for Me" and my mother turns around from the piano and said, "What about brushes?" So she was very understanding and there were rare — a rare instance where she would say na, could you hold off a minute. You know I would get home from school and say, "Mom can I drum?" And, "Okay, all right, 'till dinnertime anyway." Only rarely would she say, "Can you hold off until four o'clock? Can you wait until five o'clock?" But she was always encouraging

whoever it was. And usually the sets were scattered. Everybody had their set in their room but if there was a rehearsal or a jam session or something like that we'd bring down all the sets so there would be five sets set up and an acoustic piano.

MR: Is it true that your father attached wooden blocks to your feet so that you could reach the pedals?

CP: Yes. And I was playing along with Lionel Hampton records and Benny Goodman records and Duke Ellington records and Count Basie and Monk. You know? Whatever I was listening to.

MR: And you stated in some of your bios that at age 11 you were playing for strippers and that it opened your eyes?

CP: It opened my mind — it opened my eyes musically and anatomically.

MR: I assume you played "Night Train" on occasion then?

CP: Oh yeah, definitely.

MR: Was there a point, I'm often curious with professional musicians who've had significant success if there was a point when you were young that you made a conscious decision to go into the field? Or did it just like sort of happen?

CP: No. It's what I wanted to do from an early age. I mean as soon as I could read I was reading the backs of the albums or reading the labels on the 78s that my father had. And I was just fascinated, you know, usually somebody's liner notes, Orrin Keepnews or George Avakian or Nat Hentoff or someone you know and I would read the whole thing beginning to end and then read about the session if they had session details and then look at the credits. Oh my God Tony Williams on drums, Jo Jones on drums or whoever the drummer was. Elvin Jones on drums. And I just wanted to see my name on drums. That was — but not only the ego part of it but the process. I wanted to be in the studio and under the microphones, you know behind the microphones. And it was fascinating to me how records were made and how they did sessions and I imagined hours of rehearsal and the guys reading music and they have one take, two takes, three takes, how long did it take to get this performance that is documented here on this vinyl? The whole process was fascinating to me and I wanted to be involved in it as soon as I could.

MR: It's interesting you say that because I used to do the same thing. I was more attuned to the saxophone players so you'd see Jerome Richardson's on this one, and now I notice he's on that one and all these people like playing musical chairs and said, wow, I want to do that.

CP: Yeah. Exactly. At that early age, you know, 12, 13, I had my own bands already at school but when I saw Grady Tate, when I saw his name on an album and then saw his name on another album or I saw Joe Dukes' name on an album and then hear him in another context, you know hear him with Jack McDuff or Grady Tate with Jimmy Smith and then

hear him on a Quincy Jones album, you know, "Smackwater Jack" and hear him play a completely different style, completely different feel, and sound as comfortable as he sounded, you know, playing a shuffle with Jimmy Smith. So, and I saw him live a bunch of times, on Broadway with Lena Horne and I heard him play in that context. I said Grady Tate is like amazing. And then I finally got to meet him and we hung out, I actually played on one of his solo records where he was the main vocalist. I was really flattered that he picked me for that project. But that's one of the many people besides Jake Hanna and Sam Woodyard and Lionel Hampton himself on drums or vibes, I mean those guys were total heroes to me and I just emulated them as much as I could.

MR: Do you remember an early time, it might have been Lionel Hampton but doing a recording, doing a take then going behind the glass into the control room and listening back to yourself? Do you remember what that felt like?

CP: Yeah. I suck. I suck. I've got to practice more.

MR: How do you practice that?

CP: Recording yourself, you know at my studio I have a rudimentary set up I mean a mic on the bass drum and an overhead mic. So it's kind of like the way they recorded in the 30s or the 40s, you know one mic or maybe two mics. And record that, playing at different volumes and different feels and listen back and adjust accordingly. When I first got to New York in the 70s there was a lot, there was so much work around and a lot of it was demos, you know making demos for people. And it wasn't in the A studios, it was in the, not home studios yet but much smaller studios. So those were always great opportunities to refine your recorded performances you know listening back and saying oh yeah, that snare drum might not be the right one or maybe I can take the padding off that snare drum, open it up a little bit more and it will translate better. I remember recording at Rudy Van Gelder's, a CTI recording with Esther Phillips and Rudy Van Gelder was the engineer and you know on all those Blue Note records, I mean he was like a giant among engineers for all those Lee Morgan and Art Blakey and Grant Green I mean all those guys, Wes Montgomery records. So he came out after maybe one or two takes with this big piece of foam, a giant like piece of foam this thick and gaffer-taped it to my left leg. And I said, "What's going on?" And he said, "Oh don't worry about it, don't worry about it." So the next take we did I realized what he was doing. I was playing a rim shot, not intentionally but letting the stick hit the rim as well as the center of the drum every time I played two and four. So he put this piece of foam so that the butt of the stick could not go any further than — you know it was like three inches of foam. And I said aha. So he was getting a clear center of the drum sound as opposed to a rim shot. It made all the difference. You know when I listened back the next time I said wow, I've got to put that in my memory bank.

MR: You never forgot that, wow. And it's interesting that he didn't come out and tell you what you were doing, he just decided I'm going to fix this, I'm not going to screw around.

CP: Exactly. And he did it with white gloves on. You know he was very —

MR: And don't touch my microphones, right?

CP: Don't touch my microphones, don't touch my board.

MR: Do you have an opinion, with all the recording you've done, someone comes out and they've got, you know ten or twelve microphones on the drum set. Is it overkill? Does it affect the way you play because you kind of know that the reason they have all these microphones is they're going to fuss around with the balance?

CP: I understand the engineer's perspective, he wants to have choices — bottom of the snare drum, top of the snare drum, each tom-tom, overhead cymbals. A lot of guys these days want to have the sound from the drummer's perspective so they balance things left and right so when you listen back to it if you're a right handed drummer you're hearing the hi-hat on the right side and the ride cymbal on the left side. Which is fine you know. But I think ten or twelve microphones is overkill as far as I'm concerned. If you have the right microphone and the right distance from the drum you can get a great sound, you know? And I worked with Al Schmidt a couple of times with Tommy LiPuma and he was a master at microphone placement and the right microphone for the right drum. And it wasn't ten or twelve microphones, it might have been six — one on the bass drum, one on the snare and overhead he would sometimes mic the hi-hat and sometimes didn't mic the hi-hat, it really depended on the tune. A mic on each tom-tom but sometimes he would reduce it to just one mic between the two toms and one mic on the floor tom or one mic between the two floor toms. It really depended. If it was a ballad you know you could get away with less microphones. So ten or twelve is probably overkill but it gives the engineer the choices. You know he doesn't have to use them all or he can mix them and match them, a little of this and a little more of that. And I understand not only the need to do it for their ultimate result but technology is very seductive. You know it's tempting to have all that at your fingertips. Same thing with Pro Tools, to have all that ability to edit and cut and paste makes it amazing what you can do.

MR: I had a moment in the studio once, I wonder if you had a moment like this. The first time I saw tape sliced with a razor blade and hooked back together I said what is that? This actually works?

CP: Yeah. No it was amazing. There's some great tape operators and engineers who were amazing with a razor blade and it's a crucial, very scary moment when you see the razor blade cut the 24-track tape or 16-track tape back in the days, and then put it back together. And oh my God, it sounds okay. I even saw a guy who was working with Phil Ramone on a production at A&R slice just a square out of a 24-track tape. So not just a

razor blade but like an Exacto knife — like a little quarter inch square of tape and then replace that. Somebody hit a microphone or something and there was no other way to repair it than that.

MR: He sliced — he put a piece back in?

CP: Into the 24-track tape — I think it was on a Phoebe Snow record and I can't remember the tape op's name. He said, "No I'll do this, I'll do this, I'll fix it." And he had an Exacto knife you know and a little quarter inch square, sliced that out of the — to locate it for one thing it was amazing. But it worked you know. He got rid of the unwanted noise.

MR: You have led your own groups and I wonder if you play differently when you are leading a group than when you are not?

CP: Oh yeah. My trio is, I'm there to — a lot of them are my compositions, most of them are. So I want to play them as exuberantly as I can because I'm still exploring the tune and what feels good and what's going to work in a certain section and what's going to sound good behind the soloist and if I'm a sideman, if I'm backing somebody up I'm much more respectful of their vocal or the horn player, what they're doing. I want to be supportive. I want to be a good accompanist not a solo artist and not a drummer/composer. So yeah, there's a big difference between the two. And it depends on the type of group that I'm leading too. You know if it's my trio it's one thing and if it's an R & B kind of thing, like a new group I have called East Coast Meeting with a singer and a keyboard player. There are individual compositions but I want my voice to be integral to the group itself. So yeah.

MR: Have you ever had to — I won't say fire — did you ever have to replace somebody in a group?

CP: Yeah.

MR: Yeah that's not fun is it?

CP: No.

MR: How do you do it?

CP: Well gently. Gently and diplomatically and sometimes it's beyond my control — somebody else wants this player substituted and they have their reasons but it's up to me as the leader to not sugar coat it but diplomatically explain it. And sometimes it takes hours. You know I'm thinking of one situation where I was on the phone with this guy for three hours and he was really you know what the — he was upset and understandably so. And I would have been upset if it was me in that position and I had been in that position, so I wanted to be very sympathetic and empathetic to his feelings and make sure that he understood where I was coming from, and tried to make it clear that it wasn't a musical, you know it wasn't my musical choice. And usually, I've never had to do it where it was somebody I chose for a gig and then decided you know what this guy's not

making it. Usually I do all that evaluating and vetting before I make the first call. You know this guy's going to be great, I've heard him play, or this woman is going to be great, I've heard her play, she sounds great, I've heard her play in this context. So try to avoid a situation where halfway through the gig you know, hey you know what I'm going to have to let you go. That's tough.

MR: It is tough.

CP: Because musicians typically wear their hearts on their sleeves or on their sticks or on their — yeah.

MR: You've also played on a lot of movie soundtracks.

CP: Yeah.

MR: Was that the first time that you had used a click track or are some records made that some of the pop records you've done, did you have a click track in your headphones?

CP: Yeah it depends on the artists. Some people if they don't, if they wrote the song with the drum machine pattern or some groove they came up with on a keyboard or something like that so we'd play along to that and maybe in the studio kind of pare it down to just the cowbell or just a click or sometimes they come in with a tempo in mind and sing it at that tempo but when recording starts you know they get excited or they lose that initial feel. So I'm always very careful to take a reading kind of when we run it down the first time. I bring a metronome and take a reading on the Metronome where we are right now, this first rundown where the singer is comfortable, the red light is not on yet, this is where it feels good to them. Make a note of that marking and maybe later in the session somebody, "Geez it's not feeling good, it feels nervous, it doesn't have the energy it had." And I say, "Let's go back to the original tempo, what do you mean?" Well the original tempo was 112 BPM let's try it back there, you know and you realize they're up around 132 and wondering why it doesn't have the same groovy feel that it had. Sometimes, I mean the movies, they were up until — I don't know if they still use SMPTE but you have to be with the click because it's frame by frame, at least in the old days, so that was a different thing. But one of the first movies I did was with Paul Butterfield and Nick Gravenites and Mike Bloomfield called "Steelyard Blues" with Jane Fonda and Donald Sutherland and that was, they wrote songs for the movie and we watched the movie as we were playing the songs and sometimes the director would say, you know, "It needs a little edge on it" or "hold it back a little so that the song doesn't end before the scene ends." Little adjustments like that. There was no click, there was no SMPTE there was just the director and a big video monitor and you're watching the movie go by. Same thing with Ennio Morricone doing "Untouchables." You know there was a click but he wasn't paying attention to it. He was watching the movie go by and conducting as the scene went by so you had to really watch him and stay with him as a

conductor to make sure that it came out right. And then they underdubbed SMPTE and whatever else they needed to do the editing later.

MR: Wow. Sounds almost backwards.

CP: Well Ennio Morricone was fabulous you know. Beautiful composer and a beautiful human being and he had done this for years, and he was a trumpet player in Rome for years so he really knew the studio and knew what musicians were capable of and he had a beautiful Italian woman translating for him to the orchestra and he would sometimes send her to the drum booth, you know, to tell me to have a fantasy, you know, loosen up and feel romantic. And a couple of times I sort of played possum, "Gee what should I do here?" You know so he would have to send the translator into the drum booth.

MR: You got to have a short visit.

CP: Yeah. Tell me again what I should be doing here. That was the "Untouchables" that movie which has got some amazing scenes in it.

MR: Indeed. Did you ever have a circumstance where there's a whole orchestra recording a film and they had to do it again because of the drummer?

CP: I can't think of one.

MR: Oh good.

CP: Off hand, yeah. Not any movie that I was on. There's some that I really — are hard to listen to now. There's one called "Hoosiers" with Gene Hackman where they wanted me to play Simmons drums. And the producer and the director were really, really keen on the Simmons drum sound, all this electronic stuff. And I see the movie now, even just 30 seconds of it and it makes me cringe because the Simmons drums were so loud in the mix and it sounds so dated, you know it sounds so 70s 80s electronic music. I mean the music itself, the score is good but the drums are way, way too loud in the mix.

MR: [scats]

CP: Yeah, exactly.

MR: Oh. What do you think of the progression of the music business since — well this is a very large question but you got started in the 70s and as you said there was all kinds of work. What do you think a young musician now faces and any advice for them?

CP: Well in my mind and in my ears the young musician today has so many more advantages than I had in terms of what's available for research purposes between YouTube and all the recordings and all the different formats and all the different places they can see somebody that they want to emulate, or listen to something, download it, stream it, and practice with it 24 hours a day to get that feel, and I hear a lot of good young drummers who have done exactly that: downloaded the records, a lot of them, especially the hip hop stuff you know made with a drum machine, it's got these impossible beats because they're all programmed but the young drummer takes it at face value. You know this is

what's on the record, this is what I've got to play, and I've got to figure out a way to get that sound you know whether it means tuning the snare drum way, way high and putting a pot lid on it so it's got this metallic backbeat to it, metallic sound, or putting a piece of construction material on it like these aluminum 2 X 4 sections that they use instead of 2 X 4s these days. You compress that and it's a great metallic snare drum sound. I've used that a couple of times. And ridiculous little tiny electronic hi-hat parts, you know where they're playing 64th notes — again. But the young drummer today says, "All right, that's what I gotta do." You know the same way I did from listening to music of the 60s and 70s, emulating whatever I heard on the record, figure out how they did it, how does Jake Hanna get that sound with Woody Herman? You know is it the size of the ride cymbal or how does Ronnie Zito — getting that sound with Woody Herman. Is the snare drum wide open? Are they 15 inch hi-hats? Is it a 22 inch ride cymbal? Whatever it was, and listen to the record over and over and over again until I sound like him. So the advice I would give is the same as I've always given no matter what, whether it's 2023 or 1970 you know pick out a hero, pick out somebody you really want to emulate or a couple of guys you really want to emulate. Whether it's Bernard Purdie or Al Jackson or Roger Hawkins or Steve Gadd of course or Steve Jordan or Steve Ferroni.

MR: Or Chris Parker.

CP: Well, pick out that person and do the research. Do the homework as Richard Tee would say, "Do the homework, Stuffy." And really make yourself a musicologist in terms of style and all the different kinds of music that are out there now, my God, every single country has got its own indigenous music in the world. And oh there's a great site called Radio Farm, you can google it and it's got a world map with all these little green dots on it and you can go anywhere on the world map and click on one of these green dots and get the radio station from that country. And I go a lot to West Africa or Cuba or Jamaica. There's none — you can't get any radio stations from Russia or China. But everywhere else, you can get all the Japanese radio stations, you can get radio stations in Bulgaria and listen to Bulgarian shepherd music. So there's all kinds of resources that I didn't have when I was trying to do that. But the same basic principles still apply, you know pick out a hero, pick out somebody you want to emulate and do the research you know. Really learn about a certain musical style or learn about what that particular guy or girl, whether it's a drummer or a horn player or a singer, you know really find out what makes them tick and how they got to where they got, who they studied with or who they didn't study with. That really works for me, it has worked for me in terms of learning all different kinds of music, whether I'm the best Latin player or whether I'm the best Brazilian player, you know it doesn't really matter. It's a question of being aware of that music and be willing to emulate it.

MR: It's a terrific answer. Thank you. When you got the call to play in the Saturday Night Live band was it a no-brainer to take it or was there something about committing every Saturday that gave you pause?

CP: I considered it carefully because I was pretty busy at the time and they did say what are your weekends like. And I weighed the pros and cons about it and decided to take it because I hadn't done it before. I had done guest shots on the show since the early 70s. You know I played with a guest artist on the show, which is relatively easy. I mean you rehearse with the artist during the week somewhere and then you come Saturday morning or Saturday afternoon and rehearse again in the studio and camera blocking and all that stuff. Then there's a dress rehearsal, then you perform with the artist. So it was pretty easy. And I did enjoy that. So when they asked me to join the band I said okay I'll do it. And it got to the point where I was turning down things. Not just record dates but other tours and things that I said eh — I wish I could have done that, that would have been great. But you do commit to not only Saturday but usually a couple of other days during the week where you do pre-records. And nowadays the musical artist usually brings their own band, but in the 70s and 80s you know there were a lot of people like Leo Sayer or Eric Clapton or Elvis Costello or Linda Ronstadt, Aaron Neville, where they didn't have a band so they used a put together band from New York or they used certain members of the Saturday Night band itself to do their performance. And it was always two tunes. Now it's — I don't know if they still do two tunes or not. I haven't watched the show in a while. But yeah, it's a commitment. And God bless — Shawn Pelton's been doing it ever since I stopped you know. He's been there since '92 so it's thirty years.

MR: Anybody stand out — a particular show that comes to mind when someone like me asks about Saturday Night Live?

CP: Well the shows that we did with Stuff, you know backing up Joe Cocker. Somebody just posted them on FaceBook recently. You know we did "Feelin' All Right" with Joe Cocker and John Belushi comes out and surprises him, imitating Joe Cocker, which broke Joe Cocker's heart. I mean it was a total surprise to him. And then we do another tune, "Foots" in the second half of the show, which is really the band at its finest. You know everybody's playing great and everybody's alive. There's another show with Bryan Ferry doing I think the tune was called "The Right Stuff" which was the name of his album. And I was playing percussion, just a shaker and tambourine. Sammy Figueroa was the percussionist and Andy Newmark, great drummer, was playing with Bryan Ferry. And we rehearsed, everything was cool. And I had a relatively, you know, laid back part, shaker and tambourine, cowbell or something. So I was enjoying it, it was great. And the dress rehearsal went fine, the rehearsals went fine. Between the dress rehearsal and the actual air show Sammy Figueroa went outside, you know went to get a breath of fresh air

and he couldn't get back into the building. I don't know if he forgot his ID or somebody wouldn't let him back into the building. So it's 11:59 or something and the band is about to go on and Bryan Ferry said, "I need that conga part, I need the percussion part." And Sammy had a set-up of five drums, five congas. And I'd been digging him all week. So he said, "Can you play the conga part?" And I said uhhh sure. So I played this conga part and literally ten seconds before air I spotted Steve Jordan in the audience standing on the floor. And I said, "Steve, come on up and play." I gave him the part that I was playing, a big shaker and a cowbell and a tambourine. I said, play, we're going to do this. Air. Red light went on. So I'm playing this conga part that was killing my hands. My hands were like two pork chops after that. And Steve is playing shaker and tambourine. And we're looking at each other during the thing. And Andy Newmark is like, "What the fu—" — but it came off. So that was a very exciting show to say the least.

MR: Let me talk about — I went to your website that was just for your visual art and I scrolled — it said sketch books. And I scrolled down and I said you have almost as many sketch books as you do LP credits. It's a great idea. And it made me think — you probably are aware that both Milt Hinton and Joe Wilder carried a camera wherever they went. And they have just these kinds of pictures that no one else would get. And I was wondering, with all the — this question I have found the answer to — how did you find time to paint like this and you take it with you is that correct?

CP: Absolutely. I have a little Winsor Newton portable watercolor set that fits in with my cymbals and stick bag and I have a sketch book always. And there's often downtime, you know after the sound check or between takes sometimes or while the guitar players are overdubbing or — there is often a time where you want to stay focused, you don't want to lose the momentum or the continuity of the session and I found that having a sketch book and drawing in between takes or in those downtime periods that often happen on a session for whatever reason — you know the machine broke down or waiting for a food delivery or whatever it is — that keeps me focused. And I like going out to hear live music. If I'm not on the gig myself I want to go hear other guys play, which I've done always, you know go hear somebody that I like and check them out live. So I mentioned Shawn Pelton, I just saw him a couple of weeks ago with a great bass player, Richard Hammond at some place in Soho that I'd never been and I had a good sight line and got out the sketch book and did some things with them. You know it's hard to see everybody and people got in the way and stuff but it keeps me sort of concentrated on the music and the bar, the waiter knows don't bother this guy he's clearly involved in something else, just stick with my seltzer and lime please. Yeah, it works for me to have that alternative. You know keep the hand-eye coordination flowing until the next take.

MR: Where do you get inspiration from for your original compositions?

CP: A lot of different places. Other people's tunes, something I hear somebody say in the street sometimes or bird calls. Sometimes I'm just sitting at the piano and I come up with a bass line that's kind of cool and I say this could be something. So I make a voice memo of it. And maybe nothing happens but maybe a week later I listen to it and I say yeah, that was a cool idea, how about this? I'll add a couple of chords here and sometimes a tune is built that way. Sometimes I write lyrics. Don't ask me to sing them but I write them and sometimes they will inspire the whole tune. I'm singing the lyrics to myself or that becomes the melody but then the tune is sort of written around that form. You know here's two verses, a chorus and a bridge and another verse and two choruses. So that kind of denotes the form of the tune and gives me a melody and a bridge. It's always something different. There's a lot of composers that I really admire, you know Duke Ellington and Monk especially. And I'm often inspired by one of their tunes. Or like on this new album "Let's Cool One" is one of my favorite Monk tunes so I did like a calypso version of it. Cool-ypso.

MR: Oh yes. Have you ever had — this is sort of a change of subject — but have you ever been at like a high school jazz gathering of big bands and watched the drummer, who is so concerned with playing every possible thing written in his drum part?

CP: Yes.

MR: And if you had a chance to say something to that drummer what might it be? Or the director actually?

CP: I would never say anything to the director or the drummer unless the drummer sought me out, which has happened a couple of times — "Hey I saw you in the audience, what did you think?" And I'll take him aside and tell him exactly what I thought. In the case I'm thinking of, you know, your time is great and you're reading all the figures great, but in doing those two functions you're kind of missing the big picture. You know the big picture in this case was the dynamics. You know he started out at a certain dynamic and it never changed. I said, "You've got to tell a story about this music. You know there's an intro, there's a vamp, then there's a verse, then there's a chorus, then there's a release, then there's a bridge, then there's a breakdown. There's all these different sections and you've got to — you're in control. You're driving the bus. You are the engine that's driving the rest of the band so you've got to let them know — do you want to go fast, do you want to go slow — not fast or slow but you want to be mezzopiano? You want to be mezzoforte? Do you want to hit this section with triple forte and then come back subito piano in this next section. It's sforzando here, you've got to really put out those sign posts so that the rest of the band knows what to do. You know they've got dynamic markings too but you're the one in control of those dynamics you know, as well as the director, as well as the conductor.

MR: I have a feeling, this is just a guess, but that you were aware of almost all that material that you just mentioned by the time you really started playing out. Is that a fair statement?

CP: I didn't know the Italian words for it, you know musical words, but I knew crescendo and decrescendo and "Dimuendo and Crescendo in Blue" that Duke Ellington tune from a "Live at Newport" concert — you know those are the first two ones that I learned. And I listened to that record over and over and over again with Paul Gonsalves, 40 choruses on the blues, and Jo Jones, you know rapping a newspaper on the stage. That's a great record. Anyway by the time I was backing up strippers I knew that they have to be brought on, they have to be introduced, they have to — you have to let the audience know that the dancers are here and if they've got something to say over the microphone or one of them — we had singers too — if the singers — you've got to come down for the singers so the audience can hear what she's singing. Those things I learned pretty soon from playing with that band, and adapted it to everything I did subsequently, you know, dynamics, and listening to what's going on, listening to the singer, listening to the horn player, listening to the sections of the tune, listening to the whole song itself. What's the song about? Is it "Rainy Days and Mondays" or is it you know something more raucous you know. "Rock House" or, oh jeez.

MR: Any number of things, yeah.

CP: Yeah I'm thinking of a Ray Charles tune, "Tell the Truth."

MR: "Hallelujah I Love Her So."

CP: Oh my God that's one of my favorites, and "Hit the Road, Jack" you know has it got some grit to it? Is the singer expressing anger? Disappointment or melancholy? So all those emotional feelings have got to be incorporated into your playing as well.

MR: Thank you for that. What's up next for you?

CP: We're going to start on another, the next trio album. I've got four and a half or five things kind of ready, and we're going to rehearse next week. And I've got kind of a time crunch because the bass player Ameen Saleem now lives in Rome so he's only in New York for — I think he leaves at the end of February. And the holidays and all that stuff kind of — everybody was busy with family stuff so next week we're going to start rehearsing these new tunes of mine and try to get a feel for them and then maybe go into the studio beginning of February and start recording this stuff. It always takes longer than you think you know and the last album we just did two days in the studio but then the post-production mixing and oh you know publishing clearances and all that stuff, it always takes longer than you think. And I mentioned this other group I have, East Coast Meeting, with a great singer, Dennis Collins, and a keyboard player, Bill Heller. We have met a couple of times and have started writing stuff together, three-way compositions, and he's a great singer. And Bill is a great keyboard player and I think it's going to be

good. We're talking like going into the studio maybe not February, maybe March, and start putting these things down. And there's live gigs with that group and with a chamber ensemble, a couple of other things going on.

MR: Okay. Two quick things to wrap up with — every time I read about a review of a Bob Dylan concert they talk about how he plays these tunes different every night. Was that your experience?

CP: Absolutely.

MR: Different how?

CP: Different feel. Different cadences. Different tempos. Different keys. Luckily I was not playing a melodic instrument, but I was with him almost four years and some songs, especially the familiar ones, "Like a Rolling Stone," "It's All Over Now," "Baby Blue," "Tangled Up in Blue," "Maggie's Farm," "Subterranean Homesick Blues," things that were more often than not on the set list, at some point in the set list, if Bob thought that we knew what he was going to do he would change it immediately. He didn't want anybody to phone it in. He didn't want — he never wanted the feeling, I mean this is my perception — he never wanted anybody to take it for granted that this is the way we're going to play "Boots of Spanish Leather" because that's the way we played it last night. We're going to play it the same way tonight. No, no, no, no. Even something like "The Times They Are A Changin'" which is like a 12/8 kind of lope usually. But if he thought that we were expecting that he would put it in 4/4 or he would put it in — he would change the feel or change the key so that at least bass and guitar had to adjust and get their bearings quickly to keep up.

MR: Well how did he make it known? Did he play something on the guitar to set it up?

CP: Yeah. Or at that time he was playing mostly electric or acoustic guitar and harmonica. Now I understand he plays more keyboard. But at the time I was with him it was always guitar or acoustic guitar. And you would have to watch and listen carefully. Oop, we're not in G tonight, we're in B flat. He took it down a step or he took it up a half step you know. Maybe he felt better singing it there or lowered it a half a step to feel better singing. But God bless him you know G.E. Smith, Tony Garnier, or before Tony, Kenny Aaronsson on bass you know, adjusted quickly. All right, here we go. We're in a different key and we're in 4/4 on "Times They Are a Changin'" instead of 12/8. But he would rarely make a sound check so we would get sounds for the front of the house guys, the mixer and then Bob would be there for the show. So you never knew what to expect. And there were some, again, cliché, to use the word magical but some really magical moments, especially when he was playing acoustic guitar and harmonica, that thing made you really appreciate what a fantastic iconic artist he is. And the songs themselves, the poetry in the songs is unbelievable. He's brilliant. Always was.

MR: All right. One last Stuff related question, did anybody ever mis-identify you and Steve Gadd?

CP: Often. Often. I was playing a gig, I don't remember the name of the club, it was on Amsterdam Avenue. It's not there anymore. And the drums are set up in the window facing the street. And I was playing with somebody —oh that's bad I can't remember exactly who I was playing with but we finished a set then I played a little solo and took a break and this guy who had been watching through the window out on the street came into the club finally, you know he had wanted to avoid paying the cover charge. And that's the first thing he said to me, "Sounding good as ever, Steve." So I took it as a compliment.

MR: Yes indeed.

CP: If you sound like Steve Gadd you're doing all right.

MR: All right. Well you've been very generous with your time, and here's two quotes that I now agree with:

CP: Okay?

MR: That Tom Hanks said about you, "The hardest working man in show business." And from Tom Scott, "The sweetest human being on the planet."

CP: Awww.

MR: So you can live on that for the rest of the day, at least I would.

CP: Yeah, definitely. I appreciate your time, Monk, thanks so much for having me on the show and for interviewing. This has been great.

MR: Well good. I've really enjoyed it and I wish you all the best.

CP: All right. Same to you. Happy New Year.

MR: Same to you.